



Buying Tips

- ✓ **BATTERY USAGE:** Before purchasing a laptop, check the battery life. Be cautious, as several manufacturers indicate the battery usage time at the lowest possible power settings.
- ✓ **LEGAL SOFTWARE:** When purchasing a laptop, make sure it comes with legal software. Many end-users, or small laptop companies who build or sell laptops, may not provide you with legal copies of the software. Verify that the software that comes with your laptop is on an original CD, and has a software licence or registration number.
- ✓ **UPGRADABILITY:** This may not occur to you when you purchase a laptop, but it's important all the same. Here are some options to look for when upgrading your laptop—the RAM, the CPU, the hard drive, etc. Are the upgrades something you can do yourself, or do they require visits to a service centre?
- ✓ **LOCATION:** Before you buy a laptop, make sure you can easily return it to the dealer if it proves unsatisfactory. Also check if the dealer can service your laptop. If he can't, where's the nearest location where your laptop can be serviced?
- ✓ **HARD DRIVE:** Capacities range from 6 GB to 50 GB. Most users find 12 to 20 GB enough. In any case, you won't save much by buying a smaller capacity drive, and will pay a lot more for a larger drive than the one bundled.
- ✓ **PORTS:** Most peripheral devices connect to a USB port; make sure there are at least two USB ports. You will also need parallel (for a printer), serial, and PS/2 (for keyboard and mice) ports.
- ✓ **SIZE AND WEIGHT:** Weights range from 1.5 to 4 kg, and thicknesses could be as little as 1 inch. External power supplies and peripherals can add considerably to the weight.
- ✓ **DISPLAY:** This will require a compromise if you decide on an ultra-portable model. Most displays now support resolutions of 1024 x 768, and a 14-inch notebook display may be larger than most 15-inch desktop CRT units.
- ✓ **PROCESSOR:** Pentium III M, Pentium IV M and Athlon mobile processors are available for the laptop segment.



- 1 An inbuilt web camera to record and send photos or videos.
- 2 A speaker and Mic connection to the internal sound card.
- 3 A PCMCIA connector for add-on cards. Connectors like USB, LAN, telephone, PS/2, etc to connect external devices.
- 4 Power connector for the laptop.
- 5 A bay that can host Floppy drives as well as removable CD-ROM drives.
- 6 A battery, the source of power for the laptop, affording mobility or backup in case of a power failure.



Do Remember

- Many laptops offer large screens and can work as desktop replacements. But the larger the screen, the more difficult it will be to use the laptop in cramped locations, such as in an airplane or car.
- 'Refurbished' is a term used to describe a laptop, or any hardware device, that contains one or more components that have been used or repaired. Refurbished laptops are lower priced, and are generally a good deal for budget-conscious buyers.
- Although most manufacturers today tend to reduce the amount of documentation included with laptops, all manufacturers will include some type of paper documentation or paper inserts. Check if this includes information on upgrading, connecting the cables, and how to use the bundled software.

The Future

Laptops will have faster microprocessors with more memory. Storage may change from removable disks (floppy, Zip, CD, and DVD) to solid-state memory, which would make them even lighter and thinner. While some laptop models already have the ability to send and receive data using infrared and wireless technologies, this may become more common. In the distant future, wearable computers may eventually replace regular laptops.

Quick Find	
YOU NEED	A purely functional device that offers what any casual user might need, at an affordable price
Basic Use	
LOOK FOR	A model that has an extra bay that would hold a CD/DVD-ROM, floppy drive, add-on battery or even a CD-RW drive. These will generally offer a 13 or 14-inch XGA display and will weigh less than 3 kg
YOU NEED	Something that gives high performance, and has several extra features as well
Inter Use	
LOOK FOR	Something that gives you all the functionality of your desktop PC
YOU NEED	An ultra light notebook; something with a little panache
Prof Use	
LOOK FOR	Extremely lightweight devices that are different from the crowd